Narrative design. Change the frame.

A practical playbook for turning market insight into a story people can understand, believe, and use.

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MY POINT OF VIEW

When competitors tell the same story, they reinforce the same buying criteria. Narrative design should challenge those criteria - with a market insight customers recognize and an approach your business can credibly lead.

Strategy that ships. Stories that stick. | Edition 1.4 · October 2026

How to use this guide

Start with the decision you need to influence. Use the method at the depth the work needs.

Three ways in

- Build a narrative: work through the brief, research, five stages, and evidence mapping. Use the separate workbook to capture your decisions.
- Improve a draft: identify its central claim, run the pressure tests, and repair the earliest weak assumption. Edit the prose after the argument holds together.
- Run a workshop: bring the evidence, use the facilitation plan, and record decisions and open questions. Agreement on wording is only part of the work.

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The five stages describe the story your audience hears. Research, drafting, testing, and activation describe how you develop and use it. Keep those two ideas separate.

The onboarding example is fictional. Its scenario and capabilities illustrate the method; they are not customer findings or product-performance claims.

Start with positioning

A compelling narrative needs a clear reason for the right buyer to choose you.

Make three connected decisions

- Positioning: who should choose the product, over which alternatives, and for what value?
- Narrative: what should this audience understand differently, and how should they respond?
- Messaging: which claims, explanations, and proof will help each audience use that argument?

Write a short brief

- Audience and decision. Name the person, buying situation, and action you want to influence.
- Current approach. What would they actually use or do without you? Include existing tools, manual work, internal development, and doing nothing.
- Relevant advantage. Identify a capability that matters against those alternatives. Explain how it changes the work and which customers value that difference most.
- Product reality and proof. Record what works today, dependencies, evidence, and unresolved questions.
- Ownership. For substantial work, agree who contributes, who owns the narrative, and who decides.

If the problem is an unclear audience, an undifferentiated offer, or a missing capability, address that choice first. Better prose cannot supply the missing value.

A useful brief ends with a decision: this is the audience, this is the situation, and this is why our difference should matter. Keep unsettled choices provisional.

Find the insight

Look for a pattern that changes how a buyer understands a problem or makes a decision.



Use three kinds of signal

- Customer: recent decisions, objections, workarounds, implementation friction, and moments when expectations were missed. Preserve the context behind their words.
- Competitive: repeated promises, buying criteria, proof, and product explanations. Include the customer's actual alternatives, not just other vendors.
- Market and analyst: changes in work, expectations, economics, and technology use. Check whether a broad trend appears in your audience's experience.

Separate the steps in your reasoning

Observation: what did you see, and where?
Interpretation: what might explain it?
Implication: what should the audience prioritize or do differently?

For each source, keep its date, audience, situation, and limitations. Compare plausible explanations. One interview can reveal a useful hypothesis; it does not establish how common the problem is.

Choose a foundation worth developing

- Can a defined audience recognize the situation?
- Does it affect an important decision or outcome?
- Can your business credibly help with the response?

Ask what would disprove your interpretation. Look for contrary cases before the most attractive explanation becomes the story.

Choose the right structure

The evidence should determine the opening. Do not manufacture a market change to fit a template.

When a meaningful change is established

Use Marcus Andrews' five-stage structure: The Change → The Impact → The New Game → Why It's Hard → The Solution. Establish what changed, for whom, compared with when, and why the audience needs to respond.

When a persistent problem is misunderstood

Use this companion's reframe-led alternative: situation → contradiction → new interpretation → practical approach → barriers → product contribution → next action. This is an extension used here, not an additional Andrews framework.

For example, an onboarding checklist can be complete while the customer still cannot get value. That contradiction can support a reframe even if you have no evidence that onboarding conditions have changed over time.

When a larger story is unnecessary

Use a direct explanation of the audience, problem, value, difference, and proof. A feature announcement or short conversion page may need only part of the larger narrative.

Keep category strategy a separate choice

You can change buying criteria within a familiar category. Advocating a new category also requires buyer understanding, clear boundaries, sustained education, resources, and leadership commitment.

In the fictional example that follows, the audience has moved from single-team customers to enterprise rollouts. This explicit scenario lets us demonstrate a change-led story. In real work, establish that change before claiming it.

The Change

01

What has changed for your audience?

Identify a change in how customers work, what they expect, or what they need. Specify who it affects, what is different, and what evidence supports it.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Your customers used to get started within one team. Now an enterprise rollout needs security approval, a data integration, and several teams to be ready together.

BEFORE	NOW
One team gets started	Several teams must be ready

Apply this step

- Define the audience, situation, and comparison over time.
- Separate a technology becoming possible from people adopting it and changing their work.
- Use observed behavior and relevant research. Investigate cases where your interpretation does not fit.

PRESSURE TEST

Has onboarding actually become more interdependent for these buyers? Compare recent journeys with earlier ones.

Your draft: A specific change statement with evidence and clear limits.

The Impact

02

Why does that change matter?

Explain how the change affects a result your audience cares about. Show the connection before introducing the product.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Each team can finish its checklist while the customer still cannot use what they bought. Until those pieces come together, the value they signed up for stays out of reach.

INTERNAL CHECKLIST Tasks completed	≠	CUSTOMER OUTCOME Still unable to use the product

Apply this step

- Trace the consequence: what becomes harder, more expensive, newly possible, or expected?
- Name who owns the affected outcome. Keep the stakes proportionate.
- Include the opportunity from responding, alongside the cost of continuing as they are.

PRESSURE TEST

Where does a finished internal task still leave the customer blocked? Find a real handoff and its consequence.

Your draft: A clear consequence that gives the audience a reason to reconsider.

The New Game

03

What should people do differently?

Teach a practical approach that helps the audience respond. Explain its substance before choosing a name.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Plan onboarding around the customer's first valuable outcome. Agree what that outcome is, work back to the milestones that enable it, and measure progress against them.

Agree the first valuable outcome → Work back to enabling milestones → Measure progress toward that outcome

Apply this step

- Define what people should start, stop, and measure differently.
- Compare fairly with the current approach. Explain effort, costs, and trade-offs.
- Make the method useful with tools they already have. Then decide whether a simple name makes it easier to teach.

PRESSURE TEST

Can a team define the outcome, identify its dependencies, and tell whether the customer has reached it without buying your software?

Your draft: A method someone can explain, try, and judge.

Why It's Hard

04

What gets in the way of that approach?

Identify the real barriers to adopting the method. Include constraints your product cannot solve.

WORKED EXAMPLE

That takes a shared view of work spread across customer success, IT, and the customer's own team. When a requirement is missing, someone needs to see the gap and know who can resolve it.

Requirements -- Ownership -- Visibility

Apply this step

- Investigate ownership, incentives, skills, budget, data, integration, permissions, and behavior where relevant.
- Explain obstacles to the proposed approach, including new costs or risks it introduces.
- Acknowledge capable people working within real constraints. Avoid selecting only barriers your product happens to solve.

PRESSURE TEST

Is the obstacle visibility, unclear responsibility, or both? Software can expose a gap without settling who owns it.

Your draft: The important adoption barriers and a realistic account of responsibility.

The Solution

05

How does your product help?

Connect delivered capabilities to the barriers already established. Explain how the work changes and provide proof for the result you claim.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Our onboarding software brings requirements, owners, and milestone progress into one shared view. AI flags missing information so the responsible person can investigate what is holding the customer back.

Obstacle → Capability → How it works → Outcome → Evidence

Apply this step

- Map obstacle → capability → how it works → outcome → evidence.
- Compare with the buyer's actual alternatives. Acceptance of your approach does not establish a reason to buy your product.
- Distinguish live capabilities, required configuration, pilots, and roadmap plans. Include the human and process contribution.

PRESSURE TEST

Can the product identify the relevant gap and help the right person act? Demonstrate that workflow before claiming faster onboarding.

Your draft: A credible product contribution, a reason to choose, supporting proof, and a next action.

The complete narrative

The fictional onboarding example, as one connected story.



Dependencies must come together before the customer can progress.

The Change. Your customers used to get started within one team. Now an enterprise rollout needs security approval, a data integration, and several teams to be ready together.

The Impact. Each team can finish its checklist while the customer still cannot use what they bought. Until those pieces come together, the value they signed up for stays out of reach.

The New Game. Plan onboarding around the customer's first valuable outcome. Agree what that outcome is, work back to the milestones that enable it, and measure progress against them.

Why It's Hard. That takes a shared view of work spread across customer success, IT, and the customer's own team. When a requirement is missing, someone needs to see the gap and know who can resolve it.

The Solution. Our onboarding software brings requirements, owners, and milestone progress into one shared view. AI flags missing information so the responsible person can investigate what is holding the customer back.

Next action. Start with one customer journey. Can you trace every onboarding activity to the outcome the customer is waiting for?

The starting message named the technology: “An AI-powered platform for smarter customer onboarding.” The narrative introduces a buying criterion: the customer's first valuable outcome.

Connect claims to evidence

Different claims need different kinds of support.

Match the proof to the claim

Has the audience's world changed?

Use relevant observations over time, customer behavior, or research. Define the population and scope.

Is the approach useful?

Investigate whether it addresses the problem in the target context. Positive reactions can show interest; they do not establish effectiveness.

Can the product do the work?

Demonstrate the specific workflow, access, dependencies, and resulting state. A recommendation is different from an executed action.

Does it produce the claimed outcome?

Measure the relevant result against a suitable baseline. Include adoption, review effort, exceptions, costs, and other changes.

Build a compact claim record

For each material claim, record: wording; source and date; audience or use case; result; limitations; and status. Mark whether it is supported, partially supported, a hypothesis, or contradicted.

EXAMPLE PROOF CHAIN

Obstacle: a missing requirement blocks onboarding.
Capability: the software flags missing information.
How it works: the owner investigates and resolves the gap.
Outcome: the customer can reach the next milestone.
Proof: verify the gap, the flag, the response, and the resulting progress in that workflow.

A demo can establish a behavior under demonstrated conditions. It cannot, by itself, substantiate reliable deployment at scale or a revenue claim.

Pressure-test the argument

Twelve practical tests. Apply them to the evidence you have; record what remains unknown.

01

Change validity

Is the change real, relevant, and supported? For a reframe-led story, test the contradiction instead.

02

Audience relevance

Does it affect a specific audience's real decision? Are the stakes proportionate?

03

Differentiation

Could a competitor tell the same story unchanged? Identify a meaningful difference in interpretation, approach, product, or proof.

04

New-game strength

Can a practitioner apply the method without your product? Are actions, success, and trade-offs clear?

05

Narrative logic

Does each stage justify the next? Identify any leap from trend to urgency, approach to obstacle, or capability to outcome.

06

Customer empathy

Does the story reflect real constraints and rational reasons to keep the current approach?

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Repair the earliest weak assumption first. Then revise the stages that depend on it.

04 / PRESSURE TEST & REFINE

Challenge the strongest version

Twelve practical tests. Apply them to the evidence you have; record what remains unknown.

07

Solution credibility

Can delivered capabilities produce the result under stated conditions? Are future plans clearly separated?

08

Persuasion

Does the story combine sound reasoning, credibility, and recognizable human stakes? Does the emotion follow from the situation?

09

Commercial connection

Which buyer priority and business outcome matter? Does the value remain plausible after costs and adoption effort?

10

Competitive response

What is the strongest case for an incumbent, internal build, competitor, or doing nothing?

11

Executive challenge

Would leadership, finance, product, and sales accept the strategic choice and its implementation requirements?

12

Customer comprehension

Can an unfamiliar prospect explain the approach, product role, and next action without coaching?

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Decide: advance to a named test or use, refine a specific gap, or rebuild the premise. Simulated buyer reactions are hypotheses; real interviews and evaluations supply evidence.

04 / PRESSURE TEST & REFINE

Write for people. Explain AI.

Clear language should make the reasoning easier to follow, with the important nuance intact.

Remove words that do no work

Cut repeated explanations, generic openings, empty adjectives, and jargon that conceals the mechanism. Give each sentence a job: observation, implication, evidence, explanation, or useful human detail. Prefer concrete work over broad claims about transformation.

Check the spoken flow

- Read aloud. Mark where you lose breath, stumble, or need to explain a connection.
- Vary sentence length naturally. Keep transitions clear on first hearing.
- Ask a listener to retell the argument. Look for the idea they remember and the action they would take.

When AI matters to the story

Explain the task

What does AI do, using which inputs, and how does that help?

Explain the human role

Who sets the goal, approves actions, handles exceptions, and judges results?

Match the promise to reality

Separate possible, delivered, measured, and planned behavior. Verify the final task or system state when claiming execution.

Find the change beneath the technology

Investigate changing work and expectations; do not assume a new model feature creates an immediate market shift.

Temporarily remove AI labels. Can someone still understand the customer value and reason to choose? Restore technical terms where they add necessary precision. Keep forecasts recognizable as forecasts.

Put the story to work

Agree the argument, then adapt its emphasis to the audience and channel.

ONE SHARED ARGUMENT

Start with the core thesis and promise. Add supporting messages, relevant product mechanisms, proof, common objections, and a useful next action. Adapt depth and examples while preserving the central argument.

Choose the right application

Sales

connect the buyer's situation to the approach, then show the relevant workflow and proof. Add discovery, economics, technical detail, and next steps.

Launches and campaigns

show how a shipped capability advances the approach. A short asset can carry one part of the story.

Thought leadership

explain an observation, offer an interpretation, address a serious counterargument, and recommend a decision. Distinguish a future view from current capabilities.

Product and analyst conversations

use the narrative to examine buying criteria, unmet needs, market direction, and product priorities. Invite challenges to the premise.

Make the commitments clear

For company-level work, align leadership on the strategic choice. Ask Product to check feasibility, Sales and customer teams to check relevance, and an accountable owner to resolve decisions. Where scope is smaller, use the appropriate product or campaign team.

Assign each priority asset an audience, owner, intended action, proof requirement, and learning measure. A five-stage story prototype is a starting point, not a complete sales deck or campaign plan.

Test it. Keep it useful.

Choose a test that answers the uncertainty holding the work back.

Ask specific questions

Recognition	ask target buyers to describe a recent decision or workflow. Does the proposed tension appear without prompting?
Comprehension	show the narrative and ask people to retell it. What changed, what should they do, and how does the product help?
Usefulness and difference	compare with actual alternatives using comparable materials. Which decision changes, and why?
Delivery	evaluate the relevant product workflow under realistic conditions. Check dependencies, exceptions, and the outcome.
Behavior	use a suitable comparison or experiment. Record baseline, timing, exposure, and other changes before attributing impact.

Keep decision states clear

A draft can be coherent but untested. Internal approval does not establish buyer comprehension. Buyer comprehension does not establish purchase or revenue impact. Record what the test supports and what decision follows.

Maintain a small shared foundation

Keep audience, thesis, approach, product scope, terminology, evidence, owner, date, and approval status easy to find. Refresh examples when those change. Revisit the story when the audience, premise, alternatives, or differentiated value changes.

Use comprehension and qualified engagement as early learning signals. Investigate downstream conversion, adoption, pipeline, and revenue with an appropriate comparison. Downloads alone do not establish business impact.

05 / PUT IT TO WORK

Work through it together

Use a workshop or the AI companion to surface the decisions. Keep evidence and ownership with people.

A suggested 90-minute workshop

Beforehand: share the brief, relevant research, current story, alternatives, and product facts. Identify the owner and decision maker.

0-15 minutes	agree the audience, buying situation, decision, and evidence gaps.
15-30 minutes	compare insights and choose the supported story structure.
30-60 minutes	draft the argument, practical approach, barriers, and product contribution.
60-80 minutes	challenge the weakest link and strongest objection; repair the draft.
80-90 minutes	record decisions, unresolved questions, evidence owners, and the next test. Adjust timing to the work.

Use the downloadable AI skill

Provide the audience, objective, product facts, research, alternatives, and constraints. Ask it to distinguish evidence from assumptions. Share only material you are authorized to use.

THREE WAYS TO START

"Use Question Mode to guide me one question at a time."
"Pressure-test this draft. Find its earliest unsupported assumption and revise what depends on it."
"Adapt this agreed narrative into a sales opening using only these product facts and proof."

Ask for research, drafting, alternatives, pressure testing, experiments, refinement, voice calibration, spoken-flow review, or activation. Test simulated reactions with real customers.

METHOD & FURTHER READING

Method credits and sources

A reusable method, with clear attribution and practical extensions.

Methodological foundation

Marcus Andrews developed the five-stage Narrative Design method. This independent companion is authored by Shauna Azevedo-Brennan. The research workflow, reframe-led alternative, evidence mapping, pressure tests, AI guidance, and workbook are practical extensions used here.

Marcus Andrews

Marcus Andrews, Narrative design: How to create a story people can't ignore, Wynter (2021).
wynter.com/post/narrative-design

Marcus Andrews

Marcus Andrews, Narrative Design for Business.
m3ka.com/frameworks/narrative-design

Nancy Duarte

Nancy Duarte, structure, contrast, and audience movement.
duarte.com - structure and story

Donald Miller

Donald Miller, the customer's role in the story.
storybrand.com - Your Brand Is Not the Hero

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Continue with the separate four-page workbook and AI companion, included with this playbook in the complete toolkit.

shaunaleebrennan.github.io/shauna-ai-portfolio/playbook.html

The examples are fictional and the practical tests are diagnostic tools. Neither an AI score nor a polished draft predicts commercial effectiveness. Edition 1.4 | October 2026.